

AN INTRODUCTION TO CLOUD COMPUTING

Cloud computing allows businesses to improve their productivity while cutting ICT costs by up to 90 per cent. Let's see how

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Google's chief executive Eric Schmidt publicly uttered the term 'cloud computing' in 2006. Since then the term has taken technology by a storm. Cloud computing is all the rage now. "It's become the phrase *du jour*," says Gartner's senior analyst Ben Pring, echoing many others.

To different people there seems to be a different definition of cloud computing. An appropriate definition, however, is "Internet-based computing where shared resources, software and information are provided to computers and other devices on demand, like the electricity grid."

Cloud computing is a harmonised technology with scalable business policies. It is a versatile and flexible application of the Internet that promises to offer services like that of cloud or sky: Anytime, anywhere, by using the Internet and central remote servers to maintain data and applications. Consumers and businesses can use applications without installing any server or software.

Consider examples of hotmail.com, yahoo.com or gmail.com where no installation of server or software is required. All you need to access them is an Internet connection. These are simple examples of cloud (Internet) computing (Fig. 1). Centralising the storage, memory, processing and bandwidth allows for much more efficient computing.

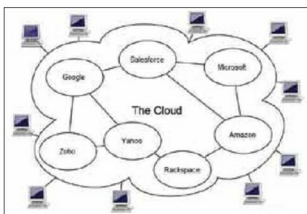


Fig. 1: Example of cloud computing

to the Internet.

As far as services are concerned, sky is the limit. Cloud computing provides services on demand via a secure online environment referred to as the 'cloud.' Customers enjoy services like e-mail, Web publishing, office tools and HR applications on a subscription basis, without installing software, buying licences

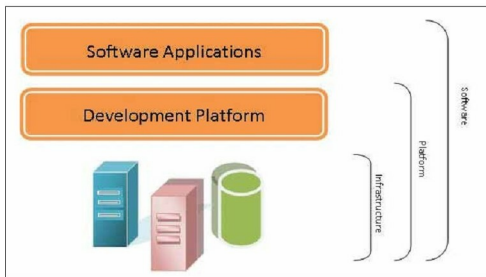


Fig. 2: Cloud computing services

Benefits of cloud computing

One of the strongest appeals of cloud computing is its ability to contract with an Internet provider for accessing the huge amount of unused or underused computational resources to deliver an amazing 'bang for the buck' computing platform with very little capital expenditure but a high-bandwidth link

or having to manage information and communication technology (ICT) infrastructure.

Bill Chang, SingTel's (Singapore Telecom) executive vice-president for business group, says, "Cloud computing allows businesses to improve their productivity, yet cut their ICT costs by up to 90 per cent. It is gaining momentum globally as broadband and smart